WS Global CIO Office
8 April 2026

Market Watch

Ceasefire optimism

Summary

Event: The US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire overnight. President Trump made the announcement on social media, conditional on a "complete, immediate and safe" opening of the Hormuz Strait. Iran's foreign minister also said Iranian armed forces would cease operations if attacks are halted.

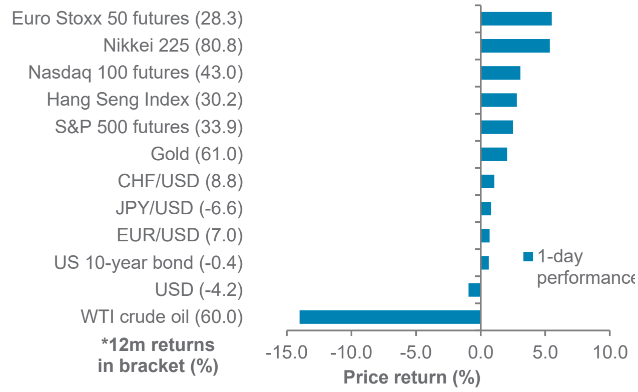
Brent oil prices fell sharply while equities and other risky assets jumped following the announcement.

Our View: The ceasefire introduces a pause after almost 6 weeks of conflict. This is consistent with our base case of a 4-6 week-long conflict and related disruption to energy supply. However, a lasting end to the conflict remains contingent on successful negotiations over the next two weeks, the details of which remain scant in the public domain.

Investment strategy: Asian equities likely to outperform in the near term given their higher sensitivity to energy prices – we prefer Taiwan, India and China markets. Falling bond yields to support our preferred Emerging Market bonds and Developed Market High Yield. Add to diversified portfolios.

Brent oil prices fell sharply while equities and other risky assets jumped after the ceasefire announcement

1-day asset performance: 7-Apr close to 8-Apr (1PM HKT/SGT)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

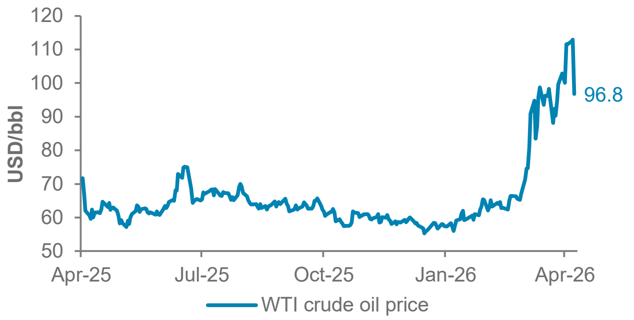
A last minute ceasefire announcement

US and Iran announce a ceasefire, likely to be followed by negotiations. The US and Iran agreed to a two week ceasefire. President Trump's announcement noted this was conditional on a *de facto* reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. While details of the ceasefire and precise nature of US-Iran conversations remain scant, several reports point to a high likelihood of the ceasefire being followed up with in-person negotiations towards a more lasting agreement.

Ceasefire announcement consistent with our base case scenario. Our base case scenario envisaged a relatively short-lived conflict, and related rise in oil prices, lasting approximately 4-6 weeks. This ceasefire announcement, coming in the 6th week of conflict, suggests an outcome largely consistent with this base case scenario.

The sharp pullback in oil prices after the ceasefire announcement is key for markets. However, prices are unlikely to move back to pre-conflict levels immediately

WTI crude oil price



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

What does this mean for investors?

Oil prices pullback sharply while risky assets rally. We expect these moves to extend over the coming 1-2 weeks. Brent oil prices pulled back sharply, falling almost 14% from yesterday's close at the time of writing. Asian equities opened sharply higher, but European and US equity futures suggest a strong open. The US 10-year bond yield moved below 4.25% while the US Dollar Index fell below 99.

Equities: Asian markets, technology sector to lead. In the near-term, we expect global equities to extend their rebound as a combination of bearish retail investor positioning and a sharp drop in oil prices unwinds recent market losses.

While most regions should do well in absolute terms, **Asian markets' relatively high sensitivity to energy prices mean they are likely to lead such a short-term rally.** Taiwan and Indian equities, two of our preferred markets, directly benefit from an easing of oil prices, but China equities (also a preferred market) should deliver strong returns as well. Near-term optimism and short-covering should also benefit the US technology sector, which we've previously pointed out benefits from strong earnings growth expectations and the smallest valuation premium to the S&P500 since 2019.

Bonds: EM bonds, DM HY to benefit. Easing oil prices mean Emerging Market (EM) bonds are expected to rebound short-term on the back of the ceasefire announcement. Developed Market High Yield (DM HY) bonds should also benefit given their risk-on nature and still-strong credit quality.

FX: USD to weaken. Easing geopolitical risks are expected to reduce safe-haven demand for the US Dollar, resulting in a pullback to its 200-day moving average at 98.5. We like the AUD as a top-ranked beneficiary of USD weakness given its hawkish central bank, but even low-rate currencies like CHF and JPY should strengthen amid USD weakness.

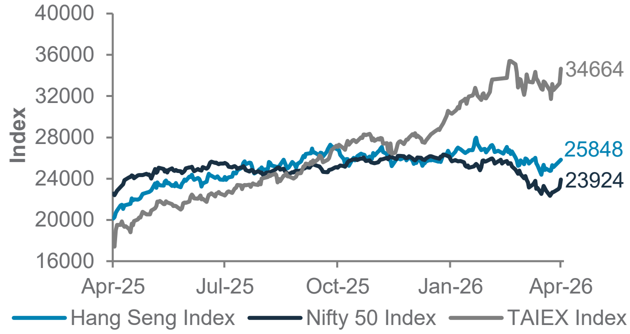
What to watch: Negotiations are key

Sustainability of positive market reaction contingent on successful negotiations. While optimism is likely to dominate the short-term market narrative, its sustainability beyond the 2-week ceasefire is dependent on positive progress towards a more lasting US-Iran agreement. We believe there is sufficient incentive for both the US and Iran to reach such an agreement as a base case, but retain caution that publicly-published demands from both sides offer little room for compromise. We also note that, given disruptions and damages in recent weeks, oil and related product output is unlikely to be able to bounce back immediately to pre-conflict levels. As investors, thus, we believe this maintains the case for holding downside hedges (we like gold and US inflation-protected bonds) alongside well-diversified portfolios.

— ***Manpreet Gill,*** *Chief Investment Officer, AMEE*

Taiwan and Indian equities, two of our preferred markets, directly benefit from an easing of oil prices

Hang Seng Index, Nifty 50 Index and TAIEX Index



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

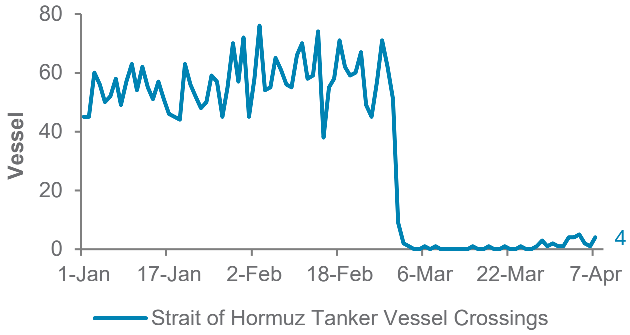
Falling bond yields to support our preferred Emerging Market bonds and Developed Market High Yield

US dollar index and US 10-year government bond yield

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

A strong rebound in tanker traffic through the Strait of Hormuz would help alleviate oil supply shortages once floating storage and prior strategic reserve releases are depleted

Strait of Hormuz tanker vessel crossings



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

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PUBLIC

WS Global CIO Office
24 March 2026

Market Watch

Gold finds strong support around USD 4,100/oz

Summary

Event: The Middle East conflict has driven gold price volatility close to the highest level since the Covid pandemic. Gold prices plunged 27% from January's all-time intraday high of USD 5595/oz to a four-month intraday low of 4,099 yesterday, before rebounding strongly to close around 4,407.

Our View: Gold initially gained in the first couple of days of the Middle East conflict due to safe haven demand, before pulling back sharply. We see this pattern often repeated during periods of heightened market stress as investors raise cash to pay margin calls or simply book profits where they can. As a result, money managers' gold positioning has turned bearish lately. The USD's recent strength on the back of a hawkish repricing of Fed rate expectations has also weighed on gold. We expect gold to remain volatile in the near-term amid demand for liquidity if the conflict continues.

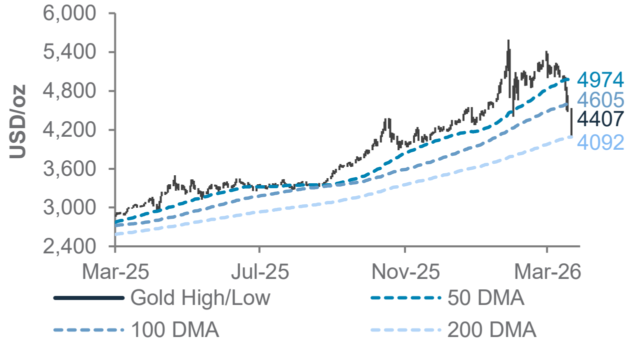
Investment strategy: We remain constructive on gold, both tactically over a 3-12-month horizon, as well as strategically. This view is primarily underpinned by structural factors, including strong Emerging Market central bank demand and investor diversification amid heightened geopolitical risks.

In our base scenario of a short-lived Middle East conflict, we also expect the USD to weaken over 6-12 months as the Fed cuts rates to revive a fragile job market. A weaker USD should again support gold prices. We have a 7% allocation to gold in our balanced diversified allocation and expect gold to rebound towards USD 5,375/oz in the next three months once the derisking phase passes. Over a 12-month period, we expect gold to gain further towards USD 5,750/oz.

Thus, we see the latest pullback as an opportunity for investors still underinvested in gold to add exposure by averaging in. On technical charts, we see strong support around the 200-day moving average of USD 4,100/oz, the level from which gold bounced back strongly yesterday. The next support is around USD 3,878/oz.

Gold found strong support yesterday around the 200-day moving average close to USD 4,100/oz

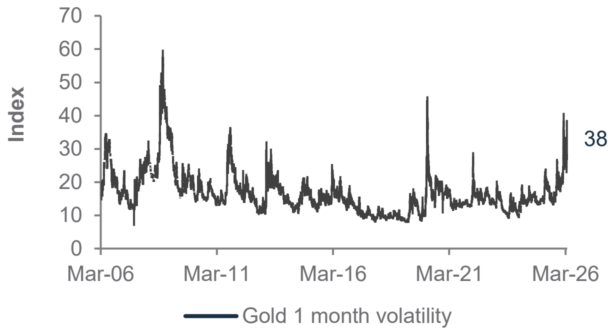
Gold price and key technical support levels



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Gold volatility has surged close to Covid pandemic highs as oil prices surged amid the Middle East conflict

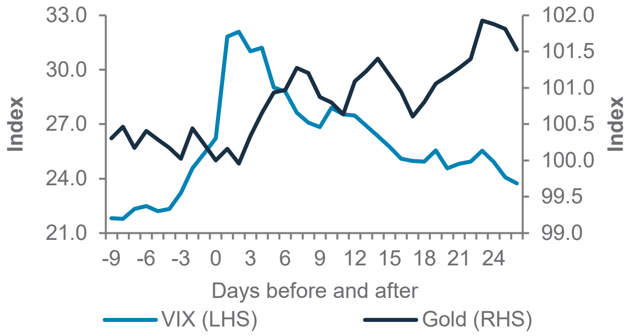
Gold one-month implied volatility



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Historically, gold's initial liquidity-driven sell-off during volatility is followed by a strong sustained rally

Average gold run over periods where VIX > 30 (2006 - now)



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Cyclical factors supporting gold

Gold has cyclical support from two primary drivers: **a) Fed policy easing and falling real rates, turning gold more attractive**: Markets have sharply repriced Fed rate expectations since the Middle East conflict escalated as oil prices surged. Markets are now anticipating the Fed to hold rates this year, vs. 50bps of cuts by December priced only a month ago. In our base scenario of a short-lived conflict, we expect the Fed to look through a near-term rise in inflation and cut rates by 50bps by end-2026 as it turns its focus, under incoming Chair Warsh, to reviving a weak US job market. This would drag US real yields lower, lifting gold.

b) Rising demand for gold as an alternative investment. The past year saw a nascent shift in investor demand towards gold bars, coins, gold-backed ETFs and digital gold. This suggests gold's rising role as an alternative investment. Among institutional investors, gold remains under-owned, with significant scope for upside.

Structural factors supporting gold

The structural drivers of gold are threefold: **a) Geopolitical uncertainty,** which has led Emerging Markets to consistently boost their gold reserves in the past four years, especially after the US and EU decisions to freeze Russian central bank assets following the Ukraine war in 2022. As of February, the top three EM central bank gold holders – China, India and Russia – had around 20%, 17% and 45% of their reserves in gold. The Middle East conflict is likely to bolster this trend.

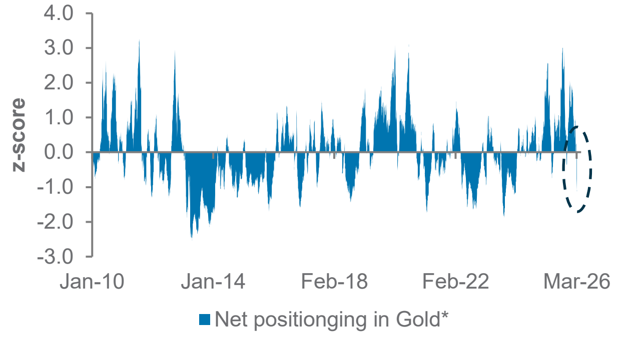
b) Concerns about expansionary fiscal policies. Fiscal policies continue to be relaxed worldwide, led by the US and Japan, with Germany joining in this year. This has raised concerns about long-term debt sustainability. The Middle East conflict is likely to further increase US debt, with the Trump administration proposing to seek Congress approval for a USD 200bn boost to defence spending. In this case, gold is seen as an antidote to profligate fiscal policies.

c) Concerns about the Fed's independence. These concerns increased last year after President Trump's decision to fire Fed Governor Cook (subsequently stayed by courts) and investigate Fed Chair Powell for expenses related to renovation of the Fed's headquarters. Trump, who has three allies in the seven-member Fed Board of Governors, will have a majority of allies on the Board if he successfully replaces Cook. Trump has also nominated long-term ally Kevin Warsh to replace Chair Powell when his term ends in May 2026 (subject to Senate confirmation). Warsh has previously called for significant rate cuts despite US inflation remaining well above the Fed's 2% target. Such a step could lead to a sharp USD depreciation, supporting gold.

— ***Rajat Bhattacharya,*** *Senior Investment Strategist*

Money managers' gold positioning has turned bearish amid search for liquidity

Net positioning in gold (z-score)



Source: VandaXAsset, Standard Chartered; *full sample z-score

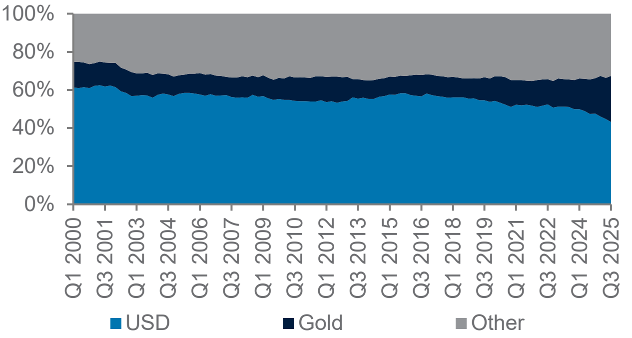
Gold's correlation with US real bond yield has turned negative again; we expect a drop in real yields, as Fed rate cut expectations return, to support gold prices

Correlation between gold and US 10-year real bond yield*

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered; *Fed 10-year real yield

Gold continues to rise as a share of global central bank reserves, mainly at the expense of the USD

Share of global central bank FX reserves



Source: IMF, World Gold Council, Standard Chartered

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